Zulia Conservancy
UGANDA

AN INVITATION TO PROFESSIONAL OUTFITTERS · 2027

Hunting at Zulia

An exclusive fair-chase hunting concession on the Uganda–South Sudan–Kenya border: two blocks, one camp, mountain and plateau country never hunted commercially, next to Kidepo Valley National Park and a new international airport.

Zulia Conservancy (Uganda) Limited · NFA Licence No. 30 · zuliaconservancy.org · amauganda@gmail.com

THE OPPORTUNITY

One concession, one operator

Zulia Central Forest Reserve covers the north-eastern corner of Uganda, from the Kidepo River to Mount Zulia (2,149 m) and the Turkana escarpment. Zulia Conservancy (Uganda) Limited holds a 50-year licence over the whole reserve from the National Forestry Authority. The licence provides for a hunting camp, with hunting under Uganda Wildlife Authority licensing, alongside photographic tourism.

We are looking for one professional outfitter to hold the exclusive hunting rights over two blocks totalling about 310 km². The rest of the reserve is set aside as photographic, community and sanctuary ground, including the 410 km² shared with the national park. This is not a volume operation. It is a small number of walk-and-stalk hunts a season in country no one else can offer, run to a standard that strengthens the reserve and its neighbours.

310 km²
exclusive hunting ground in two blocks, Lolabo and Lotukei

5 + 5 years
lease to a single operator, renewable on performance

42 km
from the main camp to the new Kidepo International Airport

WHY ZULIA

- **Nile buffalo country.** The Kidepo system is Uganda's main buffalo stronghold, and the national population is growing.
- **The Karamoja specials.** Chanler's mountain reedbuck, dik-dik and klipspringer on a 2,000 m massif and granite domes, with plains game below.
- **Exclusivity.** One operator, one 6-tent camp and no other hunting on the reserve.
- **Access.** Kidepo International Airport is under construction 21 km from the reserve boundary, and the Apoka airstrip is 23 km away. Candidate strips have been identified inside both blocks.
- **A reserve with a plan.** The concession is zoned, beaconed, counted from the air and patrolled. The community holds a fixed share of the reserve's hunting income. Clients increasingly pay for that, and ask for it.

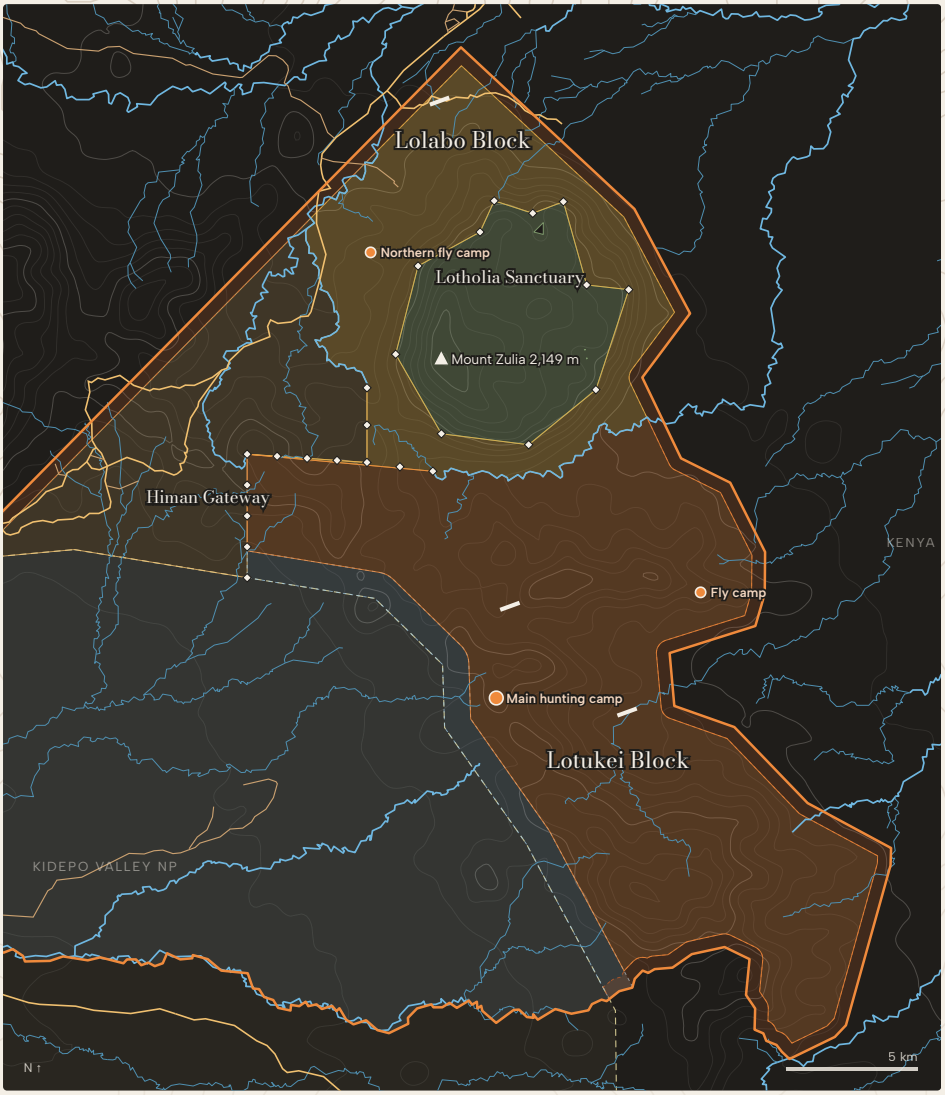


Buffalo in the Kidepo landscape. Zulia Conservancy photograph.

Status: hunting at Zulia requires the National Forestry Authority's consent, a Class A wildlife use right from the Uganda Wildlife Authority and an annual quota based on an aerial count. Zulia is securing these during 2027. No hunt may be sold or advertised until they are in place.

THE PLAN

Six zones on the ground



- Lolabo Block
- Lotukei Block
- Himan Gateway
- Lotholia Sanctuary
- Park buffer
- Border strip
- Beacon (ZH-01 to 24)
- Camp
- Candidate airstrip
- River
- Road or track

514 km²
outside the park

310 km²
hunted, in two blocks

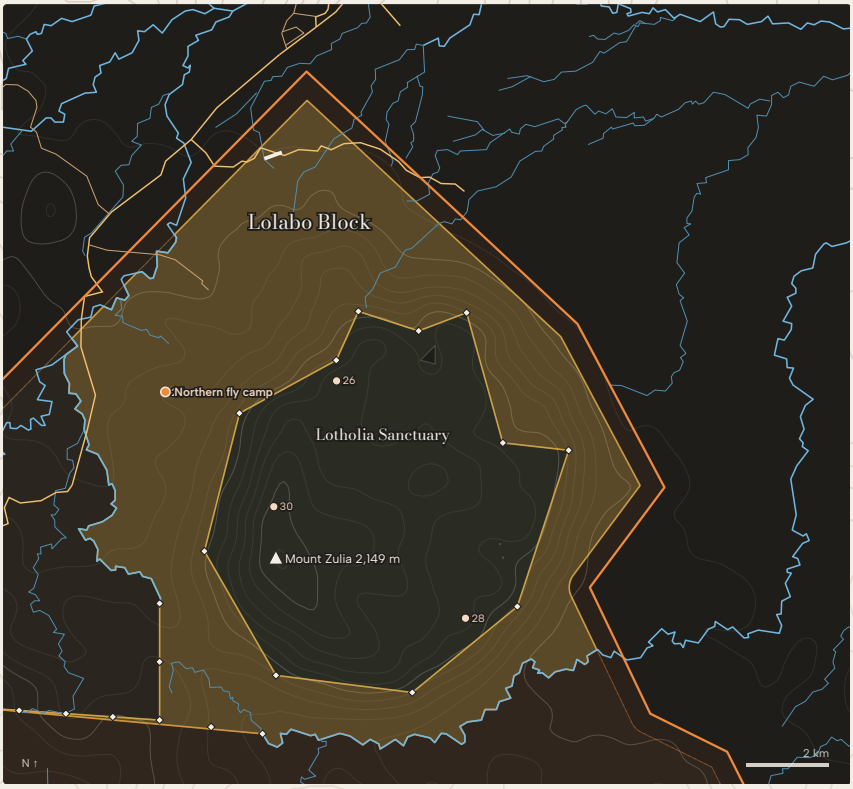
204 km²
never hunted

ZONE	AREA	USE	WHAT IT IS FOR
Lolabo Block	87 km²	Hunting	Lowlands north and east of the mountain and the Lolabo River; northern fly camp. Rotation block, and the block Zulia may run itself from year 6.
Lotukei Block	223 km²	Hunting	The plateau, domes and escarpment of the south-east; main 6-tent camp at the Plateau Camp. The core of the lease.
Himan Gateway	83 km²	No hunting	Road corridor, Himan town and the River Bluff and Gateway lodge sites. Community use, tourism and headquarters.
Lotholia Sanctuary	54 km²	No hunting	Mount Zulia above about 1,600 m, with the Summit Eyrie lodge site. Breeding refuge for klipspringer, mountain reedbuck and kudu.
Park buffer	23 km²	No shooting	1 km strip inside the boundary with Kidepo Valley National Park. Patrol and walking allowed.
Border strip	44 km²	No shooting	500 m along the South Sudan and Kenya borders. Camps and patrols allowed; no shooting towards the line.

Areas are measured on the NFA 2021 GIS boundary (WDPA) in UTM 36N and total 514 km² outside the park. Terrain is from a 400 m elevation model; rivers, roads and tracks are from OpenStreetMap. Every line is indicative until it has been walked and beaconed.

BLOCK REPORT

The Lolabo Block



Area
87 km²

Elevation
880–1,590 m

Median height
1,150 m

Rivers inside
24 km

Roads and tracks
7 km

Extent
16 × 16 km

Camp
Lolabo Foot

Strip
6 km from camp

A horseshoe of lower ground wrapped round the north, east and west of the mountain. The Lolabo River and its tributaries collect the run-off from the massif and carry it north into South Sudan. This is the reserve's best-watered country outside the park: 24 km of river inside the block, against 13 km in the much larger Lotukei Block. The ground is open savanna and bushland at 900–1,200 m, rising into broken woodland on the lower slopes of the mountain.

It is also the most accessible part of the reserve. The Lotholia–Natinga road and a track along the northern lowlands cross it, so it suits short hunts, bird shooting and a second camp. The same road means a public right of way. No shot may be taken within 500 m of it, and the block will see more people than Lotukei.

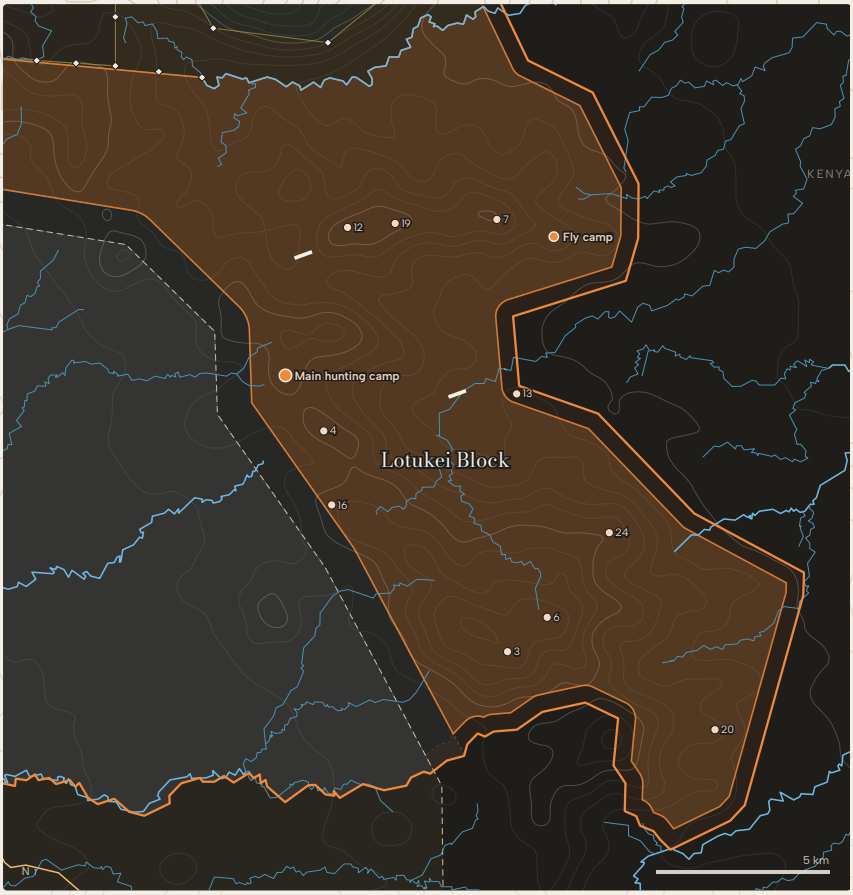
What it should hold. Dry-season buffalo along the Lolabo and its pools; Jackson's hartebeest, oribi and Bohor reedbuck on the open ground; Chanler's mountain reedbuck and klipspringer on the sanctuary edge; warthog, bushbuck, common duiker; guineafowl, francolin and sandgrouse. All of this is inference from the park and the 2022 Kidepo Game Reserve survey. The block has never been counted.

Camps and access. Northern fly camp at the Lolabo Foot (lodge site 27, 1,275 m), 4.7 km from the summit and on the track from the north. A candidate strip on the flat lowland 6 km north of camp (about 900 m elevation, 1.4 km run) needs a ground survey. By road it is 32 km from Timu and longer from Kaabong. By air the camp is 53 km from the new Kidepo International Airport.

Watch for. Cross-border movement of people and cattle from South Sudan; the public road; livestock in the dry season, which hunters mark down hard; and the sanctuary edge, where wounded animals must not be followed in without UWA's game scout.

BLOCK REPORT

The Lotukei Block



Area
223 km²

Elevation
950–1,950 m

Median height
1,300 m

Streams inside
33 km

Above 1,400 m
35%

Extent
24 × 24 km

Main camp
Plateau Camp

Strip
3.5 km from camp

The heart of the concession: a high plateau of granite domes, kopjes and wooded drainage lines that falls east over the Turkana escarpment into Kenya and west to the park boundary. It is wilder and steeper than Lolabo. A third of it lies above 1,400 m, and the domes rise 200–250 m clear of the plateau. There is no road or track inside it today.

It holds most of the reserve's lodge-site candidates, but neither of the two lodges planned under the licence. A hunting block on the plateau and photographic lodges at the River Bluff and on the summit do not meet. Any later lodge here would carve a 3 km no-shooting circle out of the block, at a pro-rata reduction in the fee.

What it should hold. Nile buffalo on the plateau and in the valleys in the dry season; Chanler's mountain reedbuck and klipspringer on the domes and escarpment; dik-dik and bushbuck in the thicket; Bohor reedbuck and oribi on the grass; warthog and bushpig. If the survey finds them, a small number of lesser kudu in the eastern thicket and Jackson's hartebeest on the open plateau. Leopard is present but may be hunted only as a problem animal, case by case.

Camps and access. Main camp at the Plateau Camp (lodge site 15, 1,648 m): water 660 m away, central, 6.7 km from the Kenyan line and 13 km from both planned lodges. Fly camp at the Lotukei Dome (site 21) for the eastern circuit. Access needs a new 15 km track from Timu in the south. A candidate strip lies on flat plateau ground 3.5 km from camp, and an alternative on the eastern lowland. By air the camp is 42 km from the new Kidepo International Airport and 470 km from Entebbe.

Watch for. The cost of the access track and strip; the border ridge (keep the camps and the shooting well inside it); fire (the plateau burns, so agree an early-burn plan with UWA and NFA); and the park buffer, where most buffalo will cross in and out.

How the lines are drawn and marked

Use what is already on the ground. The best concession lines are the ones a tracker, a scout and a herdsman all recognise without a GPS. Zulia's internal lines follow two of them. The river that runs north from the mountain's western foot to the South Sudan border separates the Himan Gateway from the Lolabo Block. The river that drains the mountain's southern foot eastwards to the Kenyan boundary separates Lolabo from Lotukei.

Beacon only where nature gives no line. Two short straight sections need beacons: the Himan Gateway's south-eastern edge (ZH-01 to ZH-11, about 12 km) and the western end of the Lolabo–Lotukei line (ZH-12 to ZH-13). The Lotholia Sanctuary follows the 1,600 m contour, which nobody can see on the ground, so it is generalised to an eleven-sided polygon with a beacon at every corner (ZH-14 to ZH-24).

Buffers by distance, signed at the tracks. The 1 km park buffer and the 500 m border strip are measured offsets. They are not beaconed along their length. A sign marks each place where a track crosses them, and every hunt's GPS log is checked against them.

The schedule prevails. The hunting agreement attaches a shapefile and a coordinate schedule as Schedule A. If a beacon is moved or lost, the coordinates govern. This is standard in gazetted African hunting areas.

The beacon standard

TYPE	SPECIFICATION
Primary beacon	Concrete pillar 30 × 30 × 120 cm, set 60 cm deep, painted white with an orange band, stamped ZH-nn. At every corner of a straight line and wherever a line crosses a track.
Line beacon	Stone cairn about 1 m high with a painted marker rock, every 1–1.5 km on straight sections and within sight of the next.
Rock-face mark	Painted orange bar and number on bedrock, used on the sanctuary corners where pillars cannot be carried.
Sign board	At each road or track entry: zone name, “No shooting” or “Hunting area – UWA permit holders only”, and a contact number. In English and Ŋakarimojoŋ.
Record	Every beacon photographed, surveyed by differential GPS and checked from the air by KEA once a year, before the season. Lost beacons replaced before any hunt in that sector.

Distances used for the buffers (1 km from the park, 500 m from the border, 2–3 km around lodges) are starting positions drawn from practice in Namibian conservancies and Niassa. They have no Ugandan statutory basis, and UWA and NFA may ask for more.

ZONES WITHOUT HUNTING

What the other 40% is for

Himan Gateway · 83 km²

The working front of the reserve: the Himan–Natinga road, Himan town and clinic, the settlements along the South Sudan border, and five of the lodge sites, including the River Bluff, which the lodge prospectus recommends as the first lodge. Hunting next to a town, a public road and the first lodge would cost more in goodwill than it earns. This is where headquarters, the community programme and photographic guests belong.

Lotholia Sanctuary · 54 km²

Mount Zulia above roughly 1,600 m: 10% of the reserve outside the park, the dry montane forest and the flagship Summit Eyrie site. Industry practice is to hold 10–20% of a concession as an unhunted breeding reservoir. The mountain is the obvious one, because it seeds klipspringer, mountain reedbuck and kudu into both blocks. Walking safaris and the summit trail run here all year.

Park buffer · 23 km²

Hunting is an offence in a national park (Wildlife Act s.29). A 1 km strip on the reserve side of the park boundary avoids any argument about animals shot on the line, and any suggestion of drawing game out of the park. It also follows the early Ugandan practice at Lake Mburo, where there was no hunting within 5 km of the park. Patrols, walking and photography continue.

Border strip · 44 km²

500 m along the South Sudan and Kenya borders. It is a safety rule: no shot towards a line people cross, and no pursuit of a wounded animal over it. Camps and patrols may use it. If UWA, the army or the police ask for a wider strip, it comes out of the blocks.

Hunting and photographic tourism on one reserve

Namibia's conservancies show the two working side by side. In 77 conservancies hunting benefits began within about 3 years and tourism within about 6, and a simulated hunting ban left fewer conservancies covering their costs than removing tourism did (Naidoo et al. 2016). Lodges there typically hold exclusive no-hunting zones of only 2% of a conservancy. Zulia gives its photographic product far more: the gateway, the mountain and the whole park side. The rules are simple. No shooting within 3 km of a lodge or photographic camp. Hunting vehicles do not use lodge game drives. Hunt dates are shared with the lodges each month of the season.

Species, season and style

Fair chase on foot. Hunting is spot-and-stalk from the camp and fly camps, in daylight only. Under Ugandan rules nothing is taken from or within 50 m of a vehicle, no dogs are used, only mature males are hunted, and a UWA game scout accompanies every hunt.

Season. December to April, when the grass is down, water is concentrated and the buffalo and hartebeest are easiest to find. Bird shooting can extend the shoulders of the season.

Quotas. UWA sets each species' quota every year from an aerial count. Every "yes" below depends on the first full count of the reserve in 2027. We would rather open with a short list and grow it than sell what the ground cannot carry.

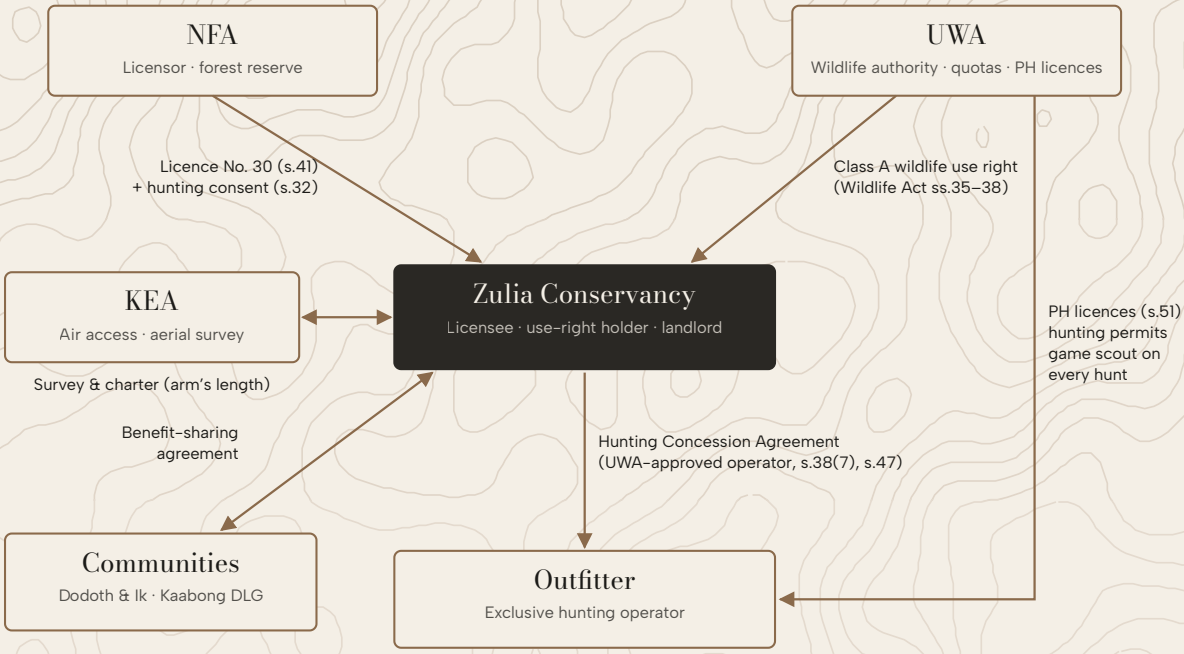
Hunting next to photographic tourism. No shooting within 3 km of any lodge or photographic camp, no hunting vehicles on lodge game drives, and hunt dates shared with the lodges each month of the season.

What the reserve is expected to offer

SPECIES	HUNTABLE AT ZULIA?	WHY
Nile buffalo	Yes: the anchor species	Kidepo is Uganda's main buffalo stronghold, national population 41,548 and rising 8.8% a year (UWA 2026)
Chanler's mountain reedbuck	Yes, after count	Karamoja special; the massif and domes are ideal habitat
Dik-dik	Yes	Karamoja special; national population about 13,500
Klipspringer	Likely, after count	Kopjes and escarpment; on the Ugandan species list but rarely offered
Bohor reedbuck · oribi · bushbuck · duiker · warthog · bushpig	Yes	Standard plains game; widespread in the Kidepo system
Jackson's hartebeest	Small, after count	37 counted across the border in 2022; present in the park
Lesser kudu	Only if the survey finds a population	Kidepo holds Uganda's only lesser kudu, about 800 nationally
Greater kudu · eland · Bright's gazelle	No	About 206 greater kudu nationally, 127 eland in the park; Bright's gazelle near-extirpated in Kidepo
Leopard · hippo · elephant · lion · giraffe · rhino	No	Leopard and hippo as problem animals only, case by case; the rest are not hunted in Uganda
Guineafowl · francolin · sandgrouse · doves	Yes	Bird shooting needs no big-game quota; good add-on and shoulder-season product

WORKING RELATIONSHIP

Who does what



Joint Hunting Committee: Zulia · outfitter · UWA warden · NFA sector manager · community representative

Zulia is the landlord and the right-holder. It holds the NFA licence and the UWA use right, sets and maintains the zoning, applies for the quota, and manages the relationships with NFA, UWA, Kaabong District and the communities. It also runs the scouts and the wildlife monitoring.

The outfitter is the operator. It markets and sells the hunts, employs the professional hunters, builds and runs the camp, and carries the client, firearm and safety risk. It hunts only inside the blocks, only on quota and only with a UWA game scout present.

Communities are a party. A benefit-sharing agreement fixes their share of Zulia's hunting income. A community representative sits on the Joint Hunting Committee, and the community has a say in local hiring and a first call on meat.

One committee, one calendar. The Joint Hunting Committee brings together Zulia, the outfitter, the UWA warden, the NFA sector manager and a community representative before and after each season.

The season cycle

WHEN	WHAT
Oct–Nov	Pre-season meeting: quota by block, hunt calendar, scouts, camp inspection, aerial check of beacons and buffers
Dec–Apr	Hunting season. UWA game scout on every hunt; permit per client before the hunt; GPS track and trophy photograph for every animal
Within 14 days of each hunt	Hunt return to Zulia and UWA: animals taken, wounded or lost, ages, locations
May–Jun	Post-season meeting: returns against quota, trophy-quality review, community payments
Jul–Sep	Annual report; quota application from the latest count; camp maintenance

The commercial method

The structure follows the practice of well-run hunting concessions in Tanzania, Zambia, Mozambique, Namibia and Botswana. The landholder keeps the trophy fees and a fixed fee. The operator earns the daily rates. A levy funds protection, the community holds a defined share, and the tenure is long enough to justify investment. Figures are set through the tender.

TERM	HOW IT WORKS
Rights granted	Exclusive hunting rights over the Lolabo and Lotukei Blocks, defined by a GPS schedule attached to the agreement. Zulia keeps all other rights: photographic tourism, walking, helicopter safaris, research and community use.
Term	Five years, renewable for a further five if the performance tests are met: fees paid, minimum hunter numbers achieved, no serious breaches, satisfactory audit. Right of first refusal on a further term.
Fixed concession fee	An annual fee, set by tender against a reserve price, phased up over the opening seasons and indexed. Paid in two instalments around the start of each season.
Trophy fees	Zulia sets the trophy-fee schedule with UWA and receives the trophy fees, out of which it pays the UWA and community shares. The outfitter sets and keeps its daily rates.
Conservation levy	A fixed amount per hunter-day and per observer-day, ring-fenced for scouts and monitoring. It is in addition to UWA's own conservation fees.
Minimum performance	From the third season, a minimum number of hunters a season, with a shortfall payment if it is not met.
Quota risk	Zulia applies for the quota and cannot guarantee it. If UWA cuts it materially for reasons outside the outfitter's control, the fixed fee falls in proportion for that season.
Trophy standards	Mature males only, with age criteria per species (buffalo hard-bossed). Every animal photographed and measured. An immature or female animal carries a penalty fee and is deducted from the next season's quota. Wounded and lost animals count against the quota.
Community	A fixed share of Zulia's hunting receipts goes into a community fund. The outfitter commits to local hiring, an annual community project and meat distribution.
Camps and access	Outfitter builds and runs a tented, removable 6-tent camp and fly camps to NFA standards. Access track and strip are co-funded by agreement. Zulia has an option to buy the camp at depreciated value at the end of the lease.
Zulia's own allocation	From the third season Zulia may market a limited share of the quota under its own name, run through the outfitter's camp at an agreed rate or by Zulia's own licensed professional hunter.
Lolabo step-back	At renewal, on 12 months' notice, Zulia may take the Lolabo Block back to run itself. The fixed fee then falls by area, and the outfitter has a right of first offer if Zulia later re-leases it.
Reporting and audit	Hunt returns within 14 days, a monthly season report and an annual report. Zulia may audit client contracts and invoices once a year.
Assignment	Hunts may be sold through booking agents. No subletting or assignment of the rights without Zulia's and UWA's written consent.
Security	Performance bond, public-liability insurance naming Zulia, and medical evacuation cover for every client.
Ending the lease	Termination for non-payment, serious breach or repeated under-performance. No-fault exit, with unused prepaid fees refunded, if Zulia's NFA licence or UWA right is lost. Disputes go to mediation and then arbitration in Kampala, with an expert panel for trophy and quota questions.

SELECTION

Who we are looking for

The operator

- Professional hunters licensed, or licensable, by UWA, with an East African track record and client references.
- A five-year plan covering marketing reach, target clients per season, pricing and staffing.
- An anti-poaching and community plan, with most camp staff hired from Kaabong.
- The capacity to post a performance bond and carry public-liability insurance.
- A clean compliance record and full disclosure of any other Ugandan concessions.
- Comfort with being audited, reporting by GPS and sharing ground with photographic tourism.

The process

1. **Expression of interest.** A short letter with company profile, professional hunters, current areas and references.
2. **Information pack and site visit.** Shortlisted firms receive the draft agreement, the beacon schedule and the aerial-count results, and are invited to walk the blocks during the 2027 dry season.
3. **Proposals.** A fixed-fee bid against the reserve price, with the business, anti-poaching and community plans.
4. **Interviews.** The best three are interviewed. Zulia selects on the whole proposal, not on price alone.
5. **Agreement.** Signature, then UWA approval of the operator and the first quota.

Timeline

WHEN	WHAT
Now – mid 2027	Expressions of interest welcome
Jan–Feb 2027	Dry-season aerial count of the reserve
2027	NFA consent, UWA use right, beaconing of the blocks; site visits for shortlisted outfitters
Late 2027	Selection and agreement; access track and camp
Jan 2028	The operator markets the first season
Dec 2028	First full season (a pilot from December 2027 if the quota allows)

EXPRESSIONS OF INTEREST

Zulia Conservancy (Uganda) Limited

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This document describes a concession in preparation. The zoning, areas and terms are indicative and may change with the aerial count, the boundary survey and the requirements of NFA and UWA. It is not an offer, and nothing in it is an advertisement of hunting.